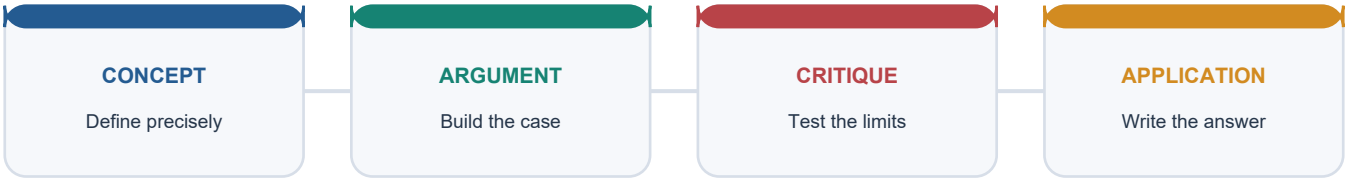
SOLVED PRACTICE WORKBOOK

Vijayanagara & the Bahmani Kingdom (Deccan) - Solved Practice Workbook

UPSC complete learning session | Foundation to advanced | Concepts, evidence, practice and answer writing

LEARNING PATH



Deterministic fallback visual: move from precise concepts through argument and critique to exam application.

Source order: repository knowledge -> official current linkage -> clearly marked analysis. No fabricated PYQs or statistics.

CONTENTS / WORKBOOK INDEX

Major learning parts and meaningful subtopics are listed in document order. Page numbers are generated from the final PDF layout; PDF bookmarks mirror the same hierarchy.

Vijayanagara & the Bahmani Kingdom (Deccan) - Solved Practice Workbook 3

BASIC MCQS / REMEDIATION 3

Part I - 32 workbook MCQs with full option-wise explanations 3

PYQS AND ANSWER PRACTICE 15

Part II - Verified direct and routed PYQs 15

Part III - Six original mains models (locked count) 18

Vijayanagara & the Bahmani Kingdom (Deccan) - Solved Practice Workbook

BASIC MCQS / REMEDIATION

Part I - 32 workbook MCQs with full option-wise explanations

Workbook MCQ 1

Question: Which combination best identifies the three recurrent strategic zones of Vijayanagara-Bahmani competition?

- A. Tungabhadra doab, Krishna-Godavari basin, and Konkan/Goa coast.
- B. Kaveri delta, Punjab plain, and Kabul corridor.
- C. Ganga-Yamuna doab, Kashmir valley, and Bengal delta.
- D. Malwa plateau, Gujarat coast, and Mewar hills.

Correct answer: A

Option-wise explanations:

- **A. Tungabhadra doab, Krishna-Godavari basin, and Konkan/Goa coast.** - Correct. This is the exact Deccan triad in the topic spine: the Tungabhadra-Raichur doab, the Krishna-Godavari basin, and the Konkan-Goa coast.
- **B. Kaveri delta, Punjab plain, and Kabul corridor.** - Incorrect. The Kaveri delta belongs to a different southern agrarian zone, while the Punjab plain and Kabul corridor are north-western theatres, not the recurrent Vijayanagara-Bahmani front.
- **C. Ganga-Yamuna doab, Kashmir valley, and Bengal delta.** - Incorrect. The Ganga-Yamuna doab, Kashmir valley and Bengal delta belong to north Indian and eastern regional histories, not to the core conflict-geography of this Deccan topic.
- **D. Malwa plateau, Gujarat coast, and Mewar hills.** - Incorrect. Malwa, Gujarat and Mewar are real medieval strategic regions, but they belong to the Topic 08 north-western state system rather than the Vijayanagara-Bahmani rivalry.

Examiner trap: founder myth without source caution

Workbook MCQ 2

Question: What is the most methodologically careful use of c. 1336?

- A. Use it to prove an unbroken and fully documented founder biography.
- B. Use it as the conventional Vijayanagara foundation anchor while qualifying contested Harihara-Bukka origins.
- C. Replace all Vijayanagara chronology with an undated legend.
- D. Treat it as the exact date of Mahmud Gawan's execution.

Correct answer: B

Option-wise explanations:

- **A. Use it to prove an unbroken and fully documented founder biography.** - Incorrect. c. 1336 is a usable chronological anchor, but it cannot prove a fully documented Harihara-Bukka biography because the Vidyaranya/conversion/origin narrative remains debated.
- **B. Use it as the conventional Vijayanagara foundation anchor while qualifying contested Harihara-Bukka origins.** - Correct. This is the methodologically safe formula: retain c. 1336 as the conventional foundation marker and qualify the contested founder narrative.
- **C. Replace all Vijayanagara chronology with an undated legend.** - Incorrect. Source criticism does not erase chronology; it only prevents a debated origin story from being treated as settled fact.
- **D. Treat it as the exact date of Mahmud Gawan's execution.** - Incorrect. Mahmud Gawan's execution belongs to 1482 Bahmani factional politics, not to Vijayanagara's conventional foundation date.

Examiner trap: dynasty-ruler mismatch

Workbook MCQ 3

Question: Which item is attached most securely to Deva Raya I?

- A. Employment of Muslim cavalrymen and archers as the signature reform.
- B. The execution of Rama Raya at Talikota.
- C. A Tungabhadra dam and canal works connected to cultivation and revenue.
- D. The eight-taraf reform of Bahmani administration.

Correct answer: C

Option-wise explanations:

- **A. Employment of Muslim cavalrymen and archers as the signature reform.** - Incorrect. The recruitment of Muslim cavalrymen and archers is the signature adaptation associated with Deva Raya II, not Deva Raya I.
- **B. The execution of Rama Raya at Talikota.** - Incorrect. Rama Raya's execution belongs to the Talikota crisis of 1565, far later than Deva Raya I's reign.
- **C. A Tungabhadra dam and canal works connected to cultivation and revenue.** - Correct. Deva Raya I is tied in the topic ledger to Tungabhadra dam-canal works that are analysed through cultivation, provisioning and revenue growth.
- **D. The eight-taraf reform of Bahmani administration.** - Incorrect. The eight-taraf administrative reform belongs to Mahmud Gawan's Bahmani programme, not to a Vijayanagara Deva Raya.

Examiner trap: zone named without mechanism

Workbook MCQ 4

Question: Which statement best describes Deva Raya II's military policy?

- A. He founded the Bahmani kingdom at Gulbarga.
- B. He abolished cavalry in favour of temple guards.
- C. He created five Deccan Sultanates after 1527.
- D. He adapted to competitive warfare by employing Muslim cavalrymen and archers.

Correct answer: D

Option-wise explanations:

- **A. He founded the Bahmani kingdom at Gulbarga.** - Incorrect. The Bahmani kingdom was founded in 1347 by Hasan Gangu/Alauddin Bahman Shah, so this statement misidentifies both ruler and polity.
- **B. He abolished cavalry in favour of temple guards.** - Incorrect. Deva Raya II is remembered for strengthening cavalry and mounted-archery capacity, not for abolishing cavalry.
- **C. He created five Deccan Sultanates after 1527.** - Incorrect. The five Deccan Sultanates emerged out of Bahmani disintegration; Deva Raya II did not create them.
- **D. He adapted to competitive warfare by employing Muslim cavalrymen and archers.** - Correct. The source base treats Deva Raya II as a ruler who adapted to competitive warfare by employing Muslim cavalrymen and archers.

Examiner trap: Deva Raya confusion

Workbook MCQ 5

Question: Why was the Tungabhadra doab politically valuable?

- A. Its fertility and frontier position made it a revenue and strategic zone.
- B. It was solely a Portuguese shipping station.
- C. It was outside all Vijayanagara-Bahmani military interaction.
- D. It contained the Bahmani madrasa at Bidar.

Correct answer: A

Option-wise explanations:

- **A. Its fertility and frontier position made it a revenue and strategic zone.** - Correct. The doab's fertility fed agrarian revenue, while its frontier position and forts made it a strategic military hinge between rival powers.
- **B. It was solely a Portuguese shipping station.** - Incorrect. A Portuguese shipping station belongs to west-coast trade logic; the Tungabhadra doab is an inland agrarian-military corridor.
- **C. It was outside all Vijayanagara-Bahmani military interaction.** - Incorrect. The doab was one of the principal theatres of Vijayanagara-Bahmani conflict, not a zone outside military interaction.
- **D. It contained the Bahmani madrasa at Bidar.** - Incorrect. The Mahmud Gawan Madrasa stood at Bidar in the Bahmani capital context, not in the Raichur-Tungabhadra doab.

Examiner trap: adaptation flattened into communal war

Workbook MCQ 6

Question: What gave the Krishna-Godavari basin a distinctive stake in rivalry?

- A. It was merely a ceremonial capital without cultivation.
- B. It combined fertile land with ports tied to regional foreign trade.
- C. It ended the need for imported horses.
- D. It was the original name for the Bidar madrasa.

Correct answer: B

Option-wise explanations:

- **A. It was merely a ceremonial capital without cultivation.** - Incorrect. The Krishna-Godavari basin is not a mere ceremonial capital; it mattered because fertile tracts and ports were tied together there.
- **B. It combined fertile land with ports tied to regional foreign trade.** - Correct. This basin mattered because agrarian strength and port-linked regional foreign trade were combined in the same contested zone.
- **C. It ended the need for imported horses.** - Incorrect. Ports in the basin connected trade networks; they did not end the strategic importance of imported horses.
- **D. It was the original name for the Bidar madrasa.** - Incorrect. Bidar Madrasa is a Bahmani educational monument, not an alternate name for the Krishna-Godavari basin.

Examiner trap: traveller praise treated as census

Workbook MCQ 7

Question: Which chain best explains the strategic value of the Konkan coast?

- A. Coastal temples eliminated the need for markets and merchants.
- B. River dams made the coast independent of sea routes.
- C. Ports connected trade and imported horses to the cavalry needs of inland states.
- D. The coast was politically irrelevant until the nineteenth century.

Correct answer: C

Option-wise explanations:

- **A. Coastal temples eliminated the need for markets and merchants.** - Incorrect. Temples did not remove the need for merchants, ports and shipping; the coast mattered precisely because commerce moved through it.
- **B. River dams made the coast independent of sea routes.** - Incorrect. Inland dams and canals could not substitute for maritime access to imported horses.
- **C. Ports connected trade and imported horses to the cavalry needs of inland states.** - Correct. The key chain is port access -> horse imports and trade -> cavalry capacity for inland Deccan states.
- **D. The coast was politically irrelevant until the nineteenth century.** - Incorrect. The Konkan coast was strategically important in the medieval Deccan; it was not a politically irrelevant shoreline awaiting the nineteenth century.

Examiner trap: amaram equated with iqta

Workbook MCQ 8

Question: What does a cautious comparison of amaram and iqta require?

- A. Treating amaram as a Bahmani word for eight tarafs.
- B. Calling both terms exactly identical because both involved revenue.
- C. Describing iqta as a Portuguese fort privilege.
- D. Attention to hereditary nayaka service and the non-transferable local stake of amaram.

Correct answer: D

Option-wise explanations:

- **A. Treating amaram as a Bahmani word for eight tarafs.** - Incorrect. Taraf is a Bahmani provincial-administrative category, whereas amaram is tied to Vijayanagara's nayaka service structure.
- **B. Calling both terms exactly identical because both involved revenue.** - Incorrect. Both concern revenue and power, but amaram cannot be flattened into iqta because hereditary local claims and service relations worked differently.
- **C. Describing iqta as a Portuguese fort privilege.** - Incorrect. Iqta is a revenue assignment concept, not a Portuguese fort privilege.
- **D. Attention to hereditary nayaka service and the non-transferable local stake of amaram.** - Correct. A cautious comparison must foreground nayaka service obligations and the more locally embedded, often hereditary character of amaram.

Examiner trap: golden-age padding without limits

Workbook MCQ 9

Question: Which is a reasonable inference from hereditary nayaka control of amaram territories?

- A. It could support mobilisation yet create limits on centralisation in crises.
- B. It prevented any regional power after 1565.
- C. It removed all local military authority from the empire.
- D. It made Vijayanagara a directly ruled Portuguese colony.

Correct answer: A

Option-wise explanations:

- **A. It could support mobilisation yet create limits on centralisation in crises.** - Correct. Hereditary control could help mobilisation in ordinary times yet make the centre bargain with powerful intermediaries in moments of crisis.
- **B. It prevented any regional power after 1565.** - Incorrect. Post-1565 nayaka and regional political power is exactly why this sweeping claim fails.
- **C. It removed all local military authority from the empire.** - Incorrect. The amaram system rested on local military authority; it did not abolish it.
- **D. It made Vijayanagara a directly ruled Portuguese colony.** - Incorrect. Vijayanagara negotiated with Portuguese actors on the coast, but it never became a directly ruled Portuguese colony.

Examiner trap: Portuguese testimony turned into archival certainty

Workbook MCQ 10

Question: Which traveller is specifically associated in the source base with seven enclosures, bazaars and canals?

- A. Hasan Gangu.
- B. Abdur Razzaq.
- C. Mahmud Gawan.
- D. Firuz Shah Bahmani.

Correct answer: B

Option-wise explanations:

- **A. Hasan Gangu.** - Incorrect. Hasan Gangu is remembered as the Bahmani founder, not as the traveller who described Vijayanagara's enclosures and bazaars.
- **B. Abdur Razzaq.** - Correct. Abdur Razzaq is the traveller used in the source base for the urban image of seven enclosures, bazaars and canals.
- **C. Mahmud Gawan.** - Incorrect. Mahmud Gawan was a Bahmani minister and reformer, not a travel observer of Vijayanagara.
- **D. Firuz Shah Bahmani.** - Incorrect. Firuz Shah Bahmani was a ruling sultan, not the traveller source attached to this city description.

Examiner trap: elite roles generalised to all women

Workbook MCQ 11

Question: How should traveller descriptions of wealth be handled?

- A. As official revenue registers issued by the court.
- B. As proof that every household had identical consumption.
- C. As valuable observer evidence to be cross-checked, not as exact statistical surveys.
- D. As reasons to ignore archaeology and inscriptions.

Correct answer: C

Option-wise explanations:

- **A. As official revenue registers issued by the court.** - Incorrect. Traveller narratives are observer accounts, not official revenue registers issued by the court.
- **B. As proof that every household had identical consumption.** - Incorrect. Visible wealth in a traveller's narrative cannot prove identical consumption across all households.
- **C. As valuable observer evidence to be cross-checked, not as exact statistical surveys.** - Correct. Travel accounts are useful evidence, but only when cross-checked against inscriptions, archaeology and genre limits.
- **D. As reasons to ignore archaeology and inscriptions.** - Incorrect. A source-critical answer uses travellers alongside archaeology and inscriptions; it does not discard those other evidence types.

Examiner trap: Bahmani stage chronology collapsed

Workbook MCQ 12

Question: What is the safest interpretation of Portuguese observations about women's expertise?

- A. They replace the need to identify author and genre.
- B. They prove all women across the empire held the same occupations.
- C. They prove women were absent from accounting and writing.
- D. They indicate visible specialised roles in the observed social world but not universal conditions.

Correct answer: D

Option-wise explanations:

- **A. They replace the need to identify author and genre.** - Incorrect. Portuguese testimony still has to be read through author, genre and observed setting.
- **B. They prove all women across the empire held the same occupations.** - Incorrect. Nuniz-like observations cannot be turned into a universal occupational profile for every woman in the empire.
- **C. They prove women were absent from accounting and writing.** - Incorrect. The route works the other way around: the source is used precisely because it notices women in accounting and related skilled roles.
- **D. They indicate visible specialised roles in the observed social world but not universal conditions.** - Correct. The safe inference is visible specialisation in the observed courtly-urban world, not a claim about uniform empire-wide conditions.

Examiner trap: Gawan made into a sultan

Workbook MCQ 13

Question: Which relation is best supported for Krishnadeva Raya and Portuguese actors?

- A. Generally cooperative relations shaped by west-coast and horse-trade pragmatism.
- B. Complete Portuguese command over Vijayanagara administration.
- C. No contact because inland courts never used ports.
- D. A Bahmani eight-taraf settlement at Bhatkal.

Correct answer: A

Option-wise explanations:

- **A. Generally cooperative relations shaped by west-coast and horse-trade pragmatism.** - Correct. The safest reading is pragmatic cooperation shaped by west-coast politics and the horse trade, not civilisational dependence.
- **B. Complete Portuguese command over Vijayanagara administration.** - Incorrect. Portuguese actors influenced coastal commerce, but they did not command Vijayanagara's internal administration.
- **C. No contact because inland courts never used ports.** - Incorrect. An inland imperial court still needed ports such as Bhatkal for overseas trade and horse supply.
- **D. A Bahmani eight-taraf settlement at Bhatkal.** - Incorrect. Eight tarafs belong to Mahmud Gawan's Bahmani reforms, so this option confuses a Bahmani administrative term with Portuguese-Vijayanagara contact.

Examiner trap: faction labels treated as racial essences

Workbook MCQ 14

Question: What is the official local status of UPSC Prelims 2024 Q56?

- A. Official Set-A key unavailable locally.
- B. Official Set-A key: option A, Krishnadevaraya.
- C. A reconstructed question with no preserved options.
- D. Official Set-A key: option B, Narasimha Saluva.

Correct answer: B

Option-wise explanations:

- **A. Official Set-A key unavailable locally.** - Incorrect. The local repository preserves the official matched answer route for this 2024 question, so it is not a key-unavailable case.
- **B. Official Set-A key: option A, Krishnadevaraya.** - Correct. The locally verified official key route settles Q56 in favour of option A, Krishnadevaraya.
- **C. A reconstructed question with no preserved options.** - Incorrect. The item is not an invented reconstruction; the option set and local key match are both preserved.
- **D. Official Set-A key: option B, Narasimha Saluva.** - Incorrect. Narasimha Saluva is a real Vijayanagara dynastic name, but the official local key does not assign him as the answer to Q56.

Examiner trap: architecture read as pure harmony proof

Workbook MCQ 15

Question: What was the Bahmani kingdom's foundation date and founder association?

- A. 1336; Harihara and Bukka.
- B. 1463; Mahmud Gawan.
- C. 1347; Hasan Gangu/Alauddin Bahman Shah.
- D. 1565; Rama Raya.

Correct answer: C

Option-wise explanations:

- **A. 1336; Harihara and Bukka.** - Incorrect. 1336 with Harihara and Bukka refers to Vijayanagara's conventional foundation anchor, not to the Bahmani kingdom.

- **B. 1463; Mahmud Gawan.** - Incorrect. 1463 belongs to Mahmud Gawan's rise to prominence, not to Bahmani state formation.
- **C. 1347; Hasan Gangu/Alauddin Bahman Shah.** - Correct. The Bahmani kingdom is conventionally dated to 1347 under Hasan Gangu, also styled Alauddin Bahman Shah.
- **D. 1565; Rama Raya.** - Incorrect. 1565 with Rama Raya marks the Talikota crisis, not the founding of the Bahmani polity.

Examiner trap: 1565 written as instant extinction

Workbook MCQ 16

Question: Which capital sequence is correct for the Bahmani kingdom?

- A. Goa followed by Dabhol under Krishnadeva Raya.
- B. Mandu followed by Ahmedabad under Mahmud Gawan.
- C. Bidar followed by Hampi under Deva Raya I.
- D. Gulbarga followed by Bidar under Ahmad Shah.

Correct answer: D

Option-wise explanations:

- **A. Goa followed by Dabhol under Krishnadeva Raya.** - Incorrect. Goa and Dabhol were strategic ports; they were never the Bahmani capital sequence.
- **B. Mandu followed by Ahmedabad under Mahmud Gawan.** - Incorrect. Mandu and Ahmedabad are the signature capitals of Malwa and Gujarat, not of the Bahmani state.
- **C. Bidar followed by Hampi under Deva Raya I.** - Incorrect. Hampi is Vijayanagara's capital, so pairing it as the second Bahmani capital collapses two different polities.
- **D. Gulbarga followed by Bidar under Ahmad Shah.** - Correct. The Bahmani capitals are Gulbarga first and Bidar later, with the shift associated with Ahmad Shah.

Examiner trap: Topic 09 expanded into later-Deccan essay

Workbook MCQ 17

Question: Which office most accurately describes Mahmud Gawan?

- A. Wakil-i-sultanat or Bahmani prime minister.
- B. Founder of the Sangama dynasty.
- C. Hereditary nayaka of the Tungabhadra doab.
- D. Portuguese captain at Goa.

Correct answer: A

Option-wise explanations:

- **A. Wakil-i-sultanat or Bahmani prime minister.** - Correct. Mahmud Gawan is best identified as wakil-i-sultanat, the leading ministerial figure in Bahmani politics.
- **B. Founder of the Sangama dynasty.** - Incorrect. The Sangama dynasty belongs to the Vijayanagara foundation story of Harihara and Bukka, not to Gawan.
- **C. Hereditary nayaka of the Tungabhadra doab.** - Incorrect. A hereditary nayaka of the Tungabhadra doab belongs to Vijayanagara's intermediary order, not to Gawan's office.
- **D. Portuguese captain at Goa.** - Incorrect. Gawan was a Bahmani statesman, not a Portuguese captain on the west coast.

Examiner trap: conventional date turned into settled biography

Workbook MCQ 18

Question: What was the administrative number linked to Mahmud Gawan's reform?

- A. Seven traveller enclosures.
- B. Eight tarafs.

- C. Five amaram districts.
- D. Four Portuguese captaincies.

Correct answer: B

Option-wise explanations:

- **A. Seven traveller enclosures.** - Incorrect. Seven enclosures comes from traveller description of Vijayanagara's cityscape, not from Gawan's administrative reform.
- **B. Eight tarafs.** - Correct. The numerical reform linked to Mahmud Gawan is the division into eight tarafs.
- **C. Five amaram districts.** - Incorrect. The topic never defines an administrative package of five amaram districts under Gawan.
- **D. Four Portuguese captaincies.** - Incorrect. Portuguese captaincies have nothing to do with the Bahmani internal reform associated with Gawan.

Examiner trap: Aravidu continuity erased

Workbook MCQ 19

Question: What was khalisa in the context of Gawan's programme?

- A. A name for the Tungabhadra canal.
- B. A Portuguese warehouse at Bhatkal.
- C. Land or resources reserved for the sultan's direct fiscal base.
- D. A hereditary nayaka title.

Correct answer: C

Option-wise explanations:

- **A. A name for the Tungabhadra canal.** - Incorrect. The Tungabhadra canal is tied to Deva Raya I's irrigation works, not to khalisa.
- **B. A Portuguese warehouse at Bhatkal.** - Incorrect. A warehouse at Bhatkal belongs to coastal trade imagery, whereas khalisa denotes resources reserved to the crown.
- **C. Land or resources reserved for the sultan's direct fiscal base.** - Correct. Khalisa refers to land or income kept under the sultan's direct fiscal control rather than left entirely to provincial magnates.
- **D. A hereditary nayaka title.** - Incorrect. A hereditary nayaka title belongs to Vijayanagara's service structure, not to the Bahmani term khalisa.

Examiner trap: Goa and horses omitted from rivalry logic

Workbook MCQ 20

Question: Why did Gawan's execution matter analytically?

- A. It restored Vijayanagara's capital after Talikota.
- B. It immediately created the Sangama dynasty.
- C. It ended all horse trade through west-coast ports.
- D. It exposed how factional politics could undo a vulnerable centralising programme.

Correct answer: D

Option-wise explanations:

- **A. It restored Vijayanagara's capital after Talikota.** - Incorrect. Hampi's devastation followed Talikota in 1565; Gawan's execution happened in 1482 within Bahmani court politics.
- **B. It immediately created the Sangama dynasty.** - Incorrect. The Sangama dynasty predates Gawan by well over a century, so his death cannot create it.
- **C. It ended all horse trade through west-coast ports.** - Incorrect. Gawan's death exposed factional fragility; it did not terminate all horse trade through the west-coast ports.
- **D. It exposed how factional politics could undo a vulnerable centralising programme.** - Correct. His execution showed how Deccani-Afaqi factional struggle could destroy a still-fragile centralising reform programme.

Examiner trap: waterworks described as ornament only

Workbook MCQ 21

Question: Which pair correctly identifies the main Bahmani elite factions?

- A. Deccanis and Afaqis/gharibs.
- B. Mamluks and Cholas.
- C. Sangamas and Tuluvas.
- D. Sharqis and Lodis.

Correct answer: A

Option-wise explanations:

- **A. Deccanis and Afaqis/gharibs.** - Correct. Deccanis and Afaqis/gharibs are the main factional labels used for Bahmani elite conflict.
- **B. Mamluks and Cholas.** - Incorrect. Mamluks and Cholas belong to very different imperial and regional settings, not to Bahmani factional vocabulary.
- **C. Sangamas and Tuluvas.** - Incorrect. Sangamas and Tuluvas are Vijayanagara dynastic names, not Bahmani court factions.
- **D. Sharqis and Lodis.** - Incorrect. Sharqis and Lodis are north Indian ruling houses, not the key factional pair inside the Bahmani sultanate.

Examiner trap: military borrowing ignored

Workbook MCQ 22

Question: What should not be inferred from the terms Deccani and Afaqi?

- A. That factional rivalry affected court politics.
- B. That each was an unchanging, uniform ethnic bloc with a single permanent interest.
- C. That office and access to influence could be politically contested.
- D. That Gawan's enemies could exploit elite divisions.

Correct answer: B

Option-wise explanations:

- **A. That factional rivalry affected court politics.** - Incorrect. This can be inferred safely: factional rivalry did shape Bahmani court politics.
- **B. That each was an unchanging, uniform ethnic bloc with a single permanent interest.** - Correct. The mistake is to essentialise Deccani and Afaqi into frozen, uniform blocs with one permanent collective interest.
- **C. That office and access to influence could be politically contested.** - Incorrect. Competition over office and access is exactly what these political labels help explain.
- **D. That Gawan's enemies could exploit elite divisions.** - Incorrect. Gawan's fall is unintelligible unless elite divisions could be mobilised against him.

Examiner trap: city mistaken for monument list

Workbook MCQ 23

Question: What did Gawan's coastal expansion towards Goa and Dabhol demonstrate?

- A. That Vijayanagara abandoned all cavalry interests.
- B. That coastal routes mattered only after the Mughal conquest.
- C. That western ports had both commercial and strategic significance.
- D. That Gulbarga was a Portuguese possession.

Correct answer: C

Option-wise explanations:

- **A. That Vijayanagara abandoned all cavalry interests.** - Incorrect. Coastal expansion to Goa and Dabhol mattered because horse and trade routes were valuable, not because cavalry ceased to matter.
- **B. That coastal routes mattered only after the Mughal conquest.** - Incorrect. The whole point of Goa and Dabhol in this topic is that coastal routes were already strategically significant in the fifteenth century.
- **C. That western ports had both commercial and strategic significance.** - Correct. Gawan's move towards Goa and Dabhol demonstrates that western ports were prized for both commerce and military supply logic.
- **D. That Gulbarga was a Portuguese possession.** - Incorrect. Gulbarga was an early Bahmani capital, never a Portuguese possession.

Examiner trap: ayagar projected unchanged across eras

Workbook MCQ 24

Question: What is the evidence value of the Mahmud Gawan Madrasa?

- A. It proves every Bahmani subject was a scholar.
- B. It proves Bidar was Vijayanagara's first capital.
- C. It is a source for the exact volume of every tax.
- D. It is material evidence of courtly educational patronage and artistic skill at Bidar.

Correct answer: D

Option-wise explanations:

- **A. It proves every Bahmani subject was a scholar.** - Incorrect. One madrasa cannot prove universal scholarship across the whole population of the Bahmani kingdom.
- **B. It proves Bidar was Vijayanagara's first capital.** - Incorrect. Bidar became a Bahmani capital; it was not Vijayanagara's first capital.
- **C. It is a source for the exact volume of every tax.** - Incorrect. The madrasa is valuable architectural evidence, but it does not function as a ledger of the exact volume of every tax.
- **D. It is material evidence of courtly educational patronage and artistic skill at Bidar.** - Correct. The Mahmud Gawan Madrasa is best used as material evidence of elite educational patronage and artistic-architectural skill at Bidar.

Examiner trap: literature detached from kingship

Workbook MCQ 25

Question: Which five successor states emerged from Bahmani disintegration?

- A. Ahmadnagar, Bijapur, Golconda, Berar and Bidar.
- B. Hampi, Madurai, Kanchipuram, Thanjavur and Srirangam.
- C. Delhi, Agra, Lahore, Kabul and Ajmer.
- D. Gujarat, Malwa, Bengal, Jaunpur and Kashmir.

Correct answer: A

Option-wise explanations:

- **A. Ahmadnagar, Bijapur, Golconda, Berar and Bidar.** - Correct. Ahmadnagar, Bijapur, Golconda, Berar and Bidar are the five standard successor states of Bahmani disintegration.
- **B. Hampi, Madurai, Kanchipuram, Thanjavur and Srirangam.** - Incorrect. Hampi, Madurai, Kanchipuram, Thanjavur and Srirangam are important southern places, not the five Deccan successor sultanates.
- **C. Delhi, Agra, Lahore, Kabul and Ajmer.** - Incorrect. Delhi, Agra, Lahore, Kabul and Ajmer are north Indian/Mughal-linked centres, not the Bahmani breakup sequence.
- **D. Gujarat, Malwa, Bengal, Jaunpur and Kashmir.** - Incorrect. Gujarat, Malwa, Bengal, Jaunpur and Kashmir are Topic 08 regional kingdoms, not the post-Bahmani successor set.

Examiner trap: coastal cooperation mistaken for dependence

Workbook MCQ 26

Question: Which statement gives the best interpretation of Talikota?

- A. It was a Bahmani victory in 1347 before Vijayanagara formed.
- B. It was a coalition victory that shattered Vijayanagara's capital and great-power phase without instant political extinction.
- C. It was a Portuguese naval battle at Bhatkal.
- D. It permanently united all Deccan states under one dynasty.

Correct answer: B

Option-wise explanations:

- **A. It was a Bahmani victory in 1347 before Vijayanagara formed.** - Incorrect. 1347 is the Bahmani foundation date, so this option confuses a state's birth with the much later battle of Talikota.
- **B. It was a coalition victory that shattered Vijayanagara's capital and great-power phase without instant political extinction.** - Correct. Talikota is best read as a coalition victory that wrecked Hampi-centred great-power primacy without erasing all later Vijayanagara continuity.
- **C. It was a Portuguese naval battle at Bhatkal.** - Incorrect. Talikota was a major inland Deccan battle, not a Portuguese naval action at Bhatkal.
- **D. It permanently united all Deccan states under one dynasty.** - Incorrect. The coalition won, but it did not permanently unify all Deccan polities under one dynasty.

Examiner trap: observer identity not specified

Workbook MCQ 27

Question: Which individual was executed in the coalition context of 1565?

- A. Harihara I.
- B. Hasan Gangu.
- C. Rama Raya.
- D. Mahmud Gawan.

Correct answer: C

Option-wise explanations:

- **A. Harihara I.** - Incorrect. Harihara I belongs to Vijayanagara's foundation era, not to the 1565 coalition crisis.
- **B. Hasan Gangu.** - Incorrect. Hasan Gangu belongs to Bahmani foundation history in 1347, not to the Talikota execution scene.
- **C. Rama Raya.** - Correct. Rama Raya was captured and executed in the coalition context of 1565.
- **D. Mahmud Gawan.** - Incorrect. Mahmud Gawan was executed in 1482 on a forged charge inside Bahmani factional politics, not at Talikota.

Examiner trap: capital shift confused with foundation

Workbook MCQ 28

Question: What remained after the 1565 destruction?

- A. A restored Bahmani kingdom at Gulbarga.
- B. No Vijayanagara-connected authority anywhere in the south.
- C. The immediate Mughal annexation of all southern territories.
- D. Aravidu rule and regional nayaka political capacity in altered form.

Correct answer: D

Option-wise explanations:

- **A. A restored Bahmani kingdom at Gulbarga.** - Incorrect. By 1565 the Bahmani kingdom had already fragmented; there was no revived Bahmani state at Gulbarga waiting to replace Vijayanagara.

- **B. No Vijayanagara-connected authority anywhere in the south.** - Incorrect. This is the textbook error the topic rejects: Vijayanagara-linked authority survived through the Aravidu line and empowered nayaka polities.
- **C. The immediate Mughal annexation of all southern territories.** - Incorrect. The Mughals did not immediately annex all southern territories in 1565.
- **D. Aravidu rule and regional nayaka political capacity in altered form.** - Correct. What remained was altered continuity-Aravidu rule from new centres and strengthened regional nayaka political capacity.

Examiner trap: centralisation assumed complete after reform

Workbook MCQ 29

Question: Which official live heritage source was used as a bounded current anchor?

- A. UNESCO World Heritage Centre's Group of Monuments at Hampi property page.
- B. A later fictional chronicle.
- C. An unverified social-media map of medieval battlefields.
- D. A coaching claim about visitor statistics.

Correct answer: A

Option-wise explanations:

- **A. UNESCO World Heritage Centre's Group of Monuments at Hampi property page.** - Correct. The package uses the UNESCO World Heritage Centre's Group of Monuments at Hampi page as its bounded current heritage anchor.
- **B. A later fictional chronicle.** - Incorrect. A fictional later chronicle cannot serve as the package's official live heritage reference.
- **C. An unverified social-media map of medieval battlefields.** - Incorrect. An unverified social-media battlefield map fails both the official-source and the heritage-status tests.
- **D. A coaching claim about visitor statistics.** - Incorrect. Coaching-platform visitor statistics are neither official heritage documentation nor a source for this package's bounded current anchor.

Examiner trap: Bidar monument used as social census

Workbook MCQ 30

Question: What does the UNESCO Hampi page securely support for this package?

- A. A full account of every fifteenth-century court office.
- B. The integrated survival of fortifications, water structures, royal and sacred complexes, markets and landscape at the capital site.
- C. Exact medieval population totals for Hampi.
- D. An official verdict on the founders' disputed origin story.

Correct answer: B

Option-wise explanations:

- **A. A full account of every fifteenth-century court office.** - Incorrect. UNESCO's property page is not a handbook of every fifteenth-century court office.
- **B. The integrated survival of fortifications, water structures, royal and sacred complexes, markets and landscape at the capital site.** - Correct. The page securely supports Hampi as an integrated capital landscape of fortifications, water systems, sacred complexes, royal spaces and markets.
- **C. Exact medieval population totals for Hampi.** - Incorrect. UNESCO does not provide exact medieval population totals for Hampi.
- **D. An official verdict on the founders' disputed origin story.** - Incorrect. A modern heritage page cannot settle the disputed founder-origin story of Harihara and Bukka.

Examiner trap: Rama Raya omitted from Talikota chain

Workbook MCQ 31

Question: Why is the phrase "Hindu bulwark" insufficient as a complete analysis of Vijayanagara?

- A. It is a precise label for Mahmud Gawan's reforms.
- B. It shows why travel accounts need no criticism.
- C. It obscures contested origin stories, pragmatic recruitment, political geography and regional interaction.
- D. It accurately explains all cavalry recruitment and port politics.

Correct answer: C

Option-wise explanations:

- **A. It is a precise label for Mahmud Gawan's reforms.** - Incorrect. Mahmud Gawan's reforms belong to Bahmani administrative history, so they cannot define Vijayanagara with the phrase "Hindu bulwark."
- **B. It shows why travel accounts need no criticism.** - Incorrect. Travel accounts remain situated observers and still require source criticism.
- **C. It obscures contested origin stories, pragmatic recruitment, political geography and regional interaction.** - Correct. The label fails because it hides debated origins, pragmatic recruitment, port-horse political economy and sustained regional interaction.
- **D. It accurately explains all cavalry recruitment and port politics.** - Incorrect. A single civilisational slogan cannot explain cavalry recruitment, coastal pragmatism and political geography all at once.

Examiner trap: successor states listed without bounded scope

Workbook MCQ 32

Question: What does the 1367 Mudkal/Tungabhadra conflict add to a mature answer?

- A. It marks the formal start of Portuguese rule at Goa.
- B. It proves the final breakup into five Sultanates.
- C. It establishes the Aravidu dynasty after 1565.
- D. It shows recurrent conflict and a reported agreement against slaughter of helpless civilians.

Correct answer: D

Option-wise explanations:

- **A. It marks the formal start of Portuguese rule at Goa.** - Incorrect. Portuguese Goa belongs to a later coastal phase and has nothing to do with the 1367 Mudkal-Tungabhadra conflict.
- **B. It proves the final breakup into five Sultanates.** - Incorrect. The final breakup into five Deccan Sultanates belongs to the later Bahmani disintegration, not to the 1367 clash.
- **C. It establishes the Aravidu dynasty after 1565.** - Incorrect. The Aravidu line emerges after the 1565 catastrophe, so this option is chronologically impossible for 1367.
- **D. It shows recurrent conflict and a reported agreement against slaughter of helpless civilians.** - Correct. The 1367 conflict adds two mature-answer points: recurrent Deccan warfare and the reported agreement against slaughter of helpless civilians.

Examiner trap: continuity minimised after Hampi sack

PYQS AND ANSWER PRACTICE

Part II - Verified direct and routed PYQs

PYQ 1 (2024, Prelims) - direct

With reference to the history of India, consider the following statements:

1. There was a game known as 'Chaturanga', which was a precursor to modern day chess, played in the court of Vijayanagara.
2. Krishnadeva Raya used to play this game with Portuguese visitors.

Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

- A. 1 only
- B. 2 only
- C. Both 1 and 2
- D. Neither 1 nor 2

Answer: D only.

How to think it through: The local review instructions lock this as a provenance-sensitive route. The well-known chess anecdote belongs to later storytelling rather than secure court evidence, and no verified Portuguese travel record in the local package supports the claim that Krishnadeva Raya routinely played such games with Portuguese visitors. Since neither statement survives source checking, the safe answer is D.

Demand decoding: This is a two-statement source-provenance question: each statement has to be tested separately against secure Vijayanagara-court evidence rather than against a familiar anecdote about chess.

Executable elimination plan: Check Statement 1 for reliable evidence that Chaturanga was actually attested in the Vijayanagara court, then test Statement 2 for a verified Portuguese record of Krishnadeva Raya playing it with visitors. If both claims fail source-checking, the route ends at D.

Why this route earns marks: It separates a later popular story from verifiable traveller evidence and therefore reaches the correct "neither" conclusion without fabricating a lost court source.

How to strengthen this route: If a future local evidence pack isolates the exact Portuguese record or its absence more precisely, cite that named source directly instead of relying on general provenance caution alone.

PYQ 2 (2024, Prelims) - direct

With reference to Vijayanagara Empire, consider the following statements:

1. It was ruled by a succession of dynasties from Sangama to Aravidu.
2. The army consisted of large contingents of infantry, cavalry, and elephants.
3. The Fort of Bhatkal was constructed by Krishnadeva Raya to protect the empire's overseas trade ports.

How many of the statements given above are correct?

- A. Only one
- B. Only two
- C. All the three
- D. None

Answer: B. Only two.

How to think it through: Statements 1 and 2 are securely supported in the local knowledge files and review ledger. Statement 3 is the route that needs caution: the official answer key settles the exam in favour of the Krishnadeva Raya option, but the exact fort-construction phrasing survives via Portuguese testimony and should not be inflated beyond that provenance. Hence two statements are correct.

Demand decoding: This is a three-statement count question in which two statements are standard core facts and the third is a provenance-sensitive construction claim; the task is to count accurately without over-reading Statement 3.

Executable elimination plan: Lock Statement 1 first (Sangama to Aravidu dynastic succession) and Statement 2 next (infantry-cavalry-elephant military composition). Then test Statement 3 narrowly: the official key accepts the Krishnadeva Raya-Bhatkal route, but the answer must preserve the Portuguese-testimony caution before selecting "Only two."

Why this route earns marks: It respects the verified 2024 official key while refusing to inflate Statement 3 into a source-unqualified architectural certainty.

How to strengthen this route: If the locally held Portuguese testimony is later cited line-for-line in the package notes, append that exact provenance so the answer explains why Statement 3 passes exam-wise yet still needs historical caution.

PYQ 3 (2021, Prelims) - routed social-history support

According to Portuguese writer Nuniz, the women in Vijayanagara Empire were experts in which of the following areas?

1. Wrestling
2. Astrology
3. Accounting
4. Soothsaying

Select the correct answer using the code given below:

- A. 1, 2 and 3 only
- B. 1, 3 and 4 only
- C. 2 and 4 only
- D. 1, 2, 3 and 4

Answer: D. 1, 2, 3 and 4.

How to think it through: This question is useful here because it enlarges Topic 09 beyond dynasties and warfare. The answer is not a claim about all women in the empire; it is a claim about what the Portuguese account noticed in a courtly and urban setting. Use it to write cautiously on specialised roles, visibility and evidence limits.

Demand decoding: This is a code-selection question about what Nuniz says he observed, not a general social-history question about all women in Vijayanagara.

Executable elimination plan: Attach each listed activity-wrestling, astrology, accounting and soothsaying-to Nuniz's observed courtly-urban description. Once none of the four drops out, the route resolves to the full combination in option D.

Why this route earns marks: It gets the code right while still guarding against the common error of turning one Portuguese observer's notice into a census-like statement about every woman in the empire.

How to strengthen this route: Name Nuniz in the first sentence and add the phrase "observed courtly-urban setting" in revision notes so the source boundary stays visible during recall.

PYQ 4 (2026, GS-I Q11, verified local official paper; routed architecture support)

Vijayanagara architecture exemplifies the amalgamation of past traditions with contemporary practices. Elucidate with examples. (15 marks, 250 words)

Verification status: Verified locally from `knowledge-export\Mains PYQ\QP-CSM-26-010926-GENERAL STUDIES PAPER - I.pdf.md`, derived from the official local scan `books\mains\2026\QP-CSM-26-010926-GENERAL STUDIES PAPER - I.pdf`. The routing ledger `upsc-ai-kit\knowledge\_PYQ-GS1-2026.md` assigns primary ownership to Indian Art & Culture, so it is used here as a routed support PYQ rather than as Topic 09's primary architecture owner.

Model answer: Vijayanagara architecture did not begin from scratch. It absorbed older South Indian temple and mandapa traditions, while adapting them to the political, ritual and urban needs of a large early-modern imperial capital. The result was continuity with innovation.

First, the empire inherited the Dravida temple base visible in sanctums, axial planning, enclosure walls and pillared halls. Yet these older forms were amplified through contemporary imperial scale. The Virupaksha complex and other Hampi temples show continuity with earlier sacred traditions, but the enlarged gopuras and ceremonial avenues projected a more expansive royal-ritual order.

Second, the period developed distinctive hall architecture and sculptural treatment. The Vitthala temple is notable for its ornate mandapas, composite pillars and the celebrated stone chariot within a highly choreographed sacred-urban setting. The Hazara Rama temple, with its Ramayana panels and royal associations, shows how narrative sculpture, court ritual and kingship could be fused.

Third, architecture in Vijayanagara was not confined to temples. Royal and metropolitan spaces such as audience zones, bazaars, tanks, canals and enclosures integrated sacred architecture with urban planning. This reflects contemporary practices of imperial display, provisioning and movement control.

Thus, Vijayanagara architecture represents an amalgamation: inherited southern forms were retained, but recast through new scales of monumentality, urban integration and imperial symbolism suited to the Deccan world of the fourteenth to sixteenth centuries.

Why this earns marks: It answers the word "amalgamation" rather than merely listing monuments: Virupaksha anchors inherited Dravida continuity, Vitthala and Hazara Rama show contemporary elaboration, and bazaars/tanks/enclosures extend the argument into imperial urban planning.

Demand decoding: "Elucidate with examples" requires showing how older South Indian temple traditions were retained and transformed in Vijayanagara, not writing a generic appreciation note on Hampi. The answer must cover both halves of the claim-past traditions and contemporary practices-with named examples inside the 250-word limit.

Executable answer/compression plan: 250 words = 1-sentence thesis on continuity with innovation; one block on inherited Dravida features (sanctum, axial plan, enclosure, gopura with Virupaksha), one on distinctive Vijayanagara elaboration (Vitthala mandapas, composite pillars, stone chariot, Hazara Rama panels), one on royal-urban integration (bazaars, tanks, canals, audience zones, enclosures), then a 1-sentence verdict.

How to improve this answer: Add one more named royal-centre example-such as the Mahanavami platform or another clearly bounded Hampi court space-to sharpen the "contemporary imperial practice" side without drifting into a full Art & Culture survey.

Part III - Six original mains models (locked count)

Original Mains 1 - 10 marks (150 words)

Question: Explain why the Raichur doab remained central to Vijayanagara-Bahmani rivalry.

Model answer: The Raichur doab mattered because it lay between the Krishna and Tungabhadra rivers and combined fertile agrarian revenue with strategic military position. Whoever controlled it gained resources for armies and prestige on a visible frontier. Its forts also linked interior command to movement across the Deccan. Repeated campaigns there therefore reflected more than territorial pride: they were contests over revenue, provisioning and the balance of power. The doab also mattered symbolically because victories there advertised a ruler's capacity before nobles and rivals. Yet the conflict should not be reduced to one strip of land alone. Control of ports, horse supply and eastern routes also shaped Deccan rivalry. Thus the doab was central because it condensed the larger fiscal-military logic of the Deccan into a single contested frontier.

Why this earns marks: It converts location into explanation: Krishna-Tungabhadra position, agrarian revenue, fort-linked strategy and frontier prestige are all tied directly to why the doab kept returning to the centre of rivalry.

Demand decoding: "Explain why" asks for causal factors, not a mere list of campaigns in the Raichur zone. The answer has to move from geography to fiscal and military consequence.

Executable answer/compression plan: 150 words = a 1-sentence location definition, then three compact reasons (fertility/revenue, frontier forts/strategy, prestige/balance of power), followed by a 1-sentence qualification that ports and horse routes also mattered.

How to improve this answer: Insert one named campaign marker-such as Krishnadevaraya's 1520 Raichur success or a specific Raichur-fort contest-to give the causal explanation one memorable historical hook.

Original Mains 2 - 10 marks (150 words)

Question: Why is Deva Raya II remembered as a ruler of adaptation rather than mere expansion?

Model answer: Deva Raya II is remembered for adaptation because his reign shows how Vijayanagara responded pragmatically to competitive Deccan warfare. Sources associate him with the recruitment of Muslim cavalrymen and archers, indicating willingness to adopt effective military practices across political-religious boundaries. This is analytically more important than a mere list of victories, because it reveals learning under pressure. His reign is also connected with urban prosperity noticed by travellers, suggesting that military adjustment worked alongside broader metropolitan strength. The key point is that Vijayanagara did not survive by static tradition alone; it altered recruitment and fighting methods when needed. However, such adaptation should not be exaggerated into complete central control or social equality. Its importance lies in showing that Deccan rivalry generated institutional borrowing as well as battlefield conflict.

Why this earns marks: The answer uses Deva Raya II's recruitment of Muslim cavalrymen and archers as named evidence, links it to learning under Bahmani pressure, and ends with a qualification against exaggerated claims of harmony or total control.

Demand decoding: The contrast word "rather than" matters: the examiner wants what made Deva Raya II adaptive in methods and recruitment, not a generic notice that his reign saw warfare or expansion.

Executable answer/compression plan: 150 words = opening contrast sentence, one evidence block on cavalry/archery recruitment and military learning, one block on prosperity/metropolitan strength under his reign, and a closing qualification against over-reading the reform.

How to improve this answer: Add Abdur Razzaq's notice of prosperity, or explicitly contrast Deva Raya II with Deva Raya I's irrigation signature, so the ruler-specific identity becomes even tighter.

Original Mains 3 - 15 marks (250 words)

Question: Evaluate the nayankara/amaram system as both a source of imperial strength and a structural limit on Vijayanagara centralisation.

Model answer: The nayankara-amaram arrangement was one of the main supports of Vijayanagara expansion because it tied local military service to revenue assignments. Through this system, the centre could mobilise armed retainers and maintain regional control without financing every layer of command through a uniform cash bureaucracy. It therefore widened imperial reach and made conquest sustainable.

Its strength lay in flexibility. Nayakas could raise troops, supervise local resources and connect the imperial court to diverse regions. In a frontier-heavy polity facing the Bahmanis and other rivals, this was a powerful fiscal-military device. It helped turn local landed power into imperial service.

At the same time, the system limited complete centralisation. Because military and revenue authority were embedded in intermediaries, hereditary tendencies and local bases of support increased the bargaining power of nayakas. In moments of succession struggle or post-war stress, these intermediaries could act with greater autonomy. This is why historians describe Vijayanagara less as a uniformly centralised bureaucracy and more as a negotiated political order.

The safest conclusion is therefore balanced. Amaram strengthened the empire by linking revenue and service, but it also made the centre dependent on regional holders of coercive power. Later references to ayagar-type local offices may illuminate village functions, yet they should not be projected uniformly across every dynasty and region. Thus imperial strength and structural limit were built into the same arrangement.

Why this earns marks: It answers both sides of the directive by showing amaram as a revenue-for-service strength and hereditary nayaka power as the corresponding limit on full centralisation, then closes with a careful ayagar caution.

Demand decoding: Because the question says "both," a one-sided definition of nayankara/amaram is insufficient; the answer must evaluate the same arrangement as a source of expansion and as a brake on uniform central control.

Executable answer/compression plan: 250 words = define nayankara/amaram in 1-2 sentences, then one body block on mobilisation and revenue advantages, one on hereditary/local bargaining power and crisis autonomy, then a balanced verdict with a brief caution against equating amaram with iqta or ayagar.

How to improve this answer: Add one explicit comparison line that amaram was more locally embedded and often more hereditary than a transferable iqta, because that contrast is a likely examiner follow-up.

Original Mains 4 - 15 marks (250 words)

Question: Discuss Mahmud Gawan's importance in Bahmani history.

Model answer: Mahmud Gawan was important because he represented the Bahmani attempt to convert a powerful but faction-ridden sultanate into a more disciplined territorial state. As wakil-i-sultanat, he combined expansion, reform and cultural patronage.

On the military and territorial side, his period is associated with successful western coastal expansion, including the capture of places such as Goa and Dabhol from rival powers. This mattered because coastal access strengthened the kingdom's commercial and strategic position.

More significant analytically were his administrative reforms. Gawan is linked with dividing the kingdom into eight tarafs, supervising fort command, enlarging khalisa lands and pressing for clearer fiscal obligations. These measures aimed to reduce the autonomy of provincial nobles and improve the crown's control over revenue and military resources. In this sense, he addressed the same fiscal-military problem that Vijayanagara handled differently through nayakas and amaram.

He was also a major patron, with the Bidar madrasa standing as a visible expression of learning and cosmopolitan court culture.

Yet his career also shows the limits of reform. Hostile factional politics, especially conflict between Deccani and Afaqi groupings, culminated in his execution on a forged charge. Therefore Gawan's significance lies not only in reform but also in demonstrating how centralising ambition could be undone by a fractured elite coalition.

Why this earns marks: The answer names Gawan's office, coastal expansion, eight-taraf and khalisa reforms, Bidar madrasa patronage and faction-driven execution, so his importance appears as both achievement and limit rather than as biography alone.

Demand decoding: "Discuss importance" requires a judgement on why Gawan mattered to Bahmani history-military, administrative, intellectual and political-not just a narrative of his life.

Executable answer/compression plan: 250 words = thesis on Gawan as centralising minister, one block on territorial/coastal significance, one on reforms (tarafs, forts, khalisa, fiscal control), one on patronage, then a concluding block on Deccani-Afaqi faction and the limits of reform.

How to improve this answer: State the year 1482 and the title wakil-i-sultanat in the opening sentence so the answer signals factual precision immediately.

Original Mains 5 - 20 marks (250 words)

Question: 'The Vijayanagara-Bahmani relationship cannot be understood only through warfare.' Examine.

Model answer: To understand the Vijayanagara-Bahmani relationship only as warfare is to miss the deeper political economy of the Deccan. Conflict was undoubtedly frequent, especially in the Raichur doab and along strategic corridors. Yet war was only one part of a larger relationship shaped by trade, military borrowing, diplomacy and shared regional constraints.

The repeated contest over the Raichur doab shows why warfare mattered: fertile land, forts and frontier prestige made the zone militarily and fiscally valuable. But the same rivalry extended to access to ports, horse imports and customs-rich coastal routes. That means both states operated within an interlinked Deccan system where commerce and war reinforced one another.

The relationship also involved adaptation across political boundaries. Deva Raya II's employment of Muslim cavalrymen and archers demonstrates that effective military practices circulated despite hostility. Likewise, Portuguese testimony on Bhatkal and horse-trade connections indicates pragmatic dealings on the coast. Such evidence weakens any simplistic "Hindu empire versus Muslim kingdom" reading.

Cultural and material interaction further complicates the picture. Monuments, court languages, educational institutions and urban practices reveal coexistence of competition with exchange. Even architecture must be read as part of a shared Deccan field of techniques and patronage, though not as evidence of perfect harmony.

Therefore the most convincing interpretation is that warfare was central but not sufficient. Vijayanagara and the Bahmanis were adversaries within a connected fiscal-military world that also generated borrowing, trade and cultural interaction.

Why this earns marks: It breaks the prompt into warfare, trade, borrowing and cultural interaction, then supports each layer with named evidence such as the Raichur doab, horse ports, Deva Raya II and Portuguese testimony.

Demand decoding: To "Examine" this claim you must challenge reductionism without denying that warfare was central. The answer therefore needs both the military core and the extra dimensions that made the relationship wider than battle alone.

Executable answer/compression plan: 250 words = opening thesis, one block on why warfare mattered (Raichur/frontier value), one on trade-horse-port logic, one on borrowing/diplomacy/cultural interaction, then a closing verdict that ties them into one connected Deccan system.

How to improve this answer: Add one named Bahmani-side example-such as Gawan's coastal expansion towards Goa and Dabhol or the Deccani-Afaqi political setting-so the evidence is not weighted too heavily towards Vijayanagara.

Original Mains 6 - 20 marks (250 words)

Question: Assess the significance of Talikota (1565) while rejecting the myth that Vijayanagara ended instantly after the battle.

Model answer: Talikota was one of the most consequential turning points in medieval South Indian history because it shattered the metropolitan concentration of Vijayanagara power, yet it did not instantly erase the polity or all its successor formations.

Its immediate significance was enormous. The Deccan sultanate coalition defeated the forces associated with Rama Raya, who was captured and killed. Hampi, the great capital, was then devastated. Since the city had concentrated ritual authority, market exchange, monumental legitimacy and political symbolism, its destruction affected the entire imperial structure. Talikota was therefore not just a battlefield defeat but a systemic rupture.

However, the standard textbook line that "the empire ended in 1565" is inaccurate. The Aravidu line continued from Penukonda and later Chandragiri, while regional nayaka powers operated with greater autonomy. Political forms, claims to legitimacy and elements of imperial continuity survived beyond the sack of Hampi.

The balanced judgement is thus twofold. First, Talikota decisively ended Vijayanagara's phase as the dominant Hampi-centred great power of the Deccan. Second, it did not produce instant civilisational extinction. Post-1565 history is better read as altered continuity: new centres emerged, old intermediaries gained room to manoeuvre, and the successor sultanates of Ahmadnagar, Bijapur, Golconda, Bidar and Berar shaped the next Deccan order. Talikota matters most when catastrophe and continuity are held together.

Why this earns marks: It does the two tasks embedded in the question: Talikota is treated as a systemic rupture through Rama Raya's death and Hampi's sack, but the answer then corrects the myth of instant extinction by naming Aravidu, Penukonda and Chandragiri.

Demand decoding: "Assess the significance ... while rejecting the myth" requires a two-part judgement: explain why 1565 mattered enormously and then explicitly disprove the textbook shorthand that Vijayanagara simply ended that same day.

Executable answer/compression plan: 250 words = opening thesis on rupture without total erasure, one block on battlefield outcome and metropolitan devastation, one block on post-1565 continuity under Aravidu and new centres, then a verdict distinguishing loss of Hampi-centred primacy from complete disappearance.

How to improve this answer: Move Penukonda and Chandragiri into the main body rather than leaving them implicit in the conclusion, so the continuity evidence appears as concrete proof rather than as a final assertion.